



another whose art underwent such rapid changes both in content as well as language. In his early phase he was influenced by Rabindranath Tagore, which he overcame later. A recurring symbol in his poems during this period was that of a cloud, which was a symbol of revolution. Later on, he moved to longer poems such as *Ram ki Shakti Pooja* and *Saroj Smriti* which are supposed to be his greatest achievements in poetry. He wrote some satirical poems as well. Two political personalities he loved to comment on in both prose and poetry were Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru. With Gandhi, his ruse was light-hearted and had to do with one of the latter's comment that Hindi literature did not have a Tagore. With Nehru the differences were more fundamental. To Nirala, for whom the common man was the indisputable focus of everything in life, Nehru was an outsider. He was extremely critical of Nehru's western upbringing and felt the leader could not relate to the problems of the poor.

In similar vein he was also critical of those communists whose class character was different from common people. In his poem *Moscow Dialogues*, Nirala chides the so-called champions of the common man for their distance from the lives of the poor. In the third phase, he indulged his love for experimentation in verse form and wrote some smaller poems in an earthy language. He addresses the Almighty but at the same time questions his existence. The 21st century reader will find he can relate easily to his later work, embodied in the collections, *Naye Patte* and *Bela*. This list would also inevitably include his satirical poem *Kukurmutta*. Nirala's prose writing would also have resonance, especially *Khulli Bhat* and *Billesur Bakariha*.

Perhaps Nirala's greatest contribution was his freeing of poetry into blank verse, accompanied by the parallel liberation of the human spirit



he captured so well. His use of blank verse changed the destiny of Hindi poetry. Of course, even after this, Nirala continued to write in rhymed structures, ably demonstrating his dexterity in both forms. Nirala was also one of the greatest lyricists of his time, indicating his enormous capacity for discovering new emotional elements and integrating them successfully with classical grace.

Born out of the freedom struggle, Nirala's poetry echoed the ethos of that longing. I was first exposed to Nirala's poetry in school but the first time I got an opportunity to hear him was when he visited our school in Banaras on the occasion of Tulsi Jayanti. I remember distinctly that he had recited his complete work, *Tulsidas*. I also remember, equally distinctly, that even though I had not understood the poem at that time, I was spellbound by its magical recitation. I learned something valuable that day—that some things can fascinate us even though we may not comprehend them.

It was many years later, in my final year of BA, that I was able to meet Nirala. He was eating, in his

small room, in a little bylane of the Daraganj locality of Allahabad, when I reached there, accompanying the writer Trilochan Shastri. I still remember his demeanour while eating—he ate as if he was sitting before the food in an attitude of complete respect, head lowered. We did not disturb him. It was only when he had finished, that Trilochanji introduced me to him, as a young, budding poet. Much of the conversation is now a dim memory but one thing stands out. I got one of the softest, sweetest scoldings of my life. It seemed to me to contain an invaluable key to understanding Nirala's poetry.

This was contained in reference to *lokbhumi* and *lokbhasha* (which was Awadhi, in Nirala's context). It liberated Nirala from the initial Bengali influence and ultimately brought him back to the soil of Awadh. This is captured in the spirit of his last works. Nirala was truly one of the greatest poets of modern India, transcending the boundaries of space and time.

The author is a Hindi poet and critic

Q: Which languages was he fluent in?

A: Bangla, English, Sanskrit, and Hindi

Q: Who persuaded him to learn Hindi?

A: His wife Anohar Devi

Q: What was his greatest contribution to Hindi literature?

A: He started the use of blank verse

Q: Which illness was he said to suffer from?

A: Schizophrenia

Q: Which popular Bangla novel did he translate into Hindi?

A: Bankimchandra Chatterjee's *Anand Math*